

YUE LI

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UCL

Education

University College London, UK

MPhil/Ph.D. Economics, 2023 to 2027 (expected)

University College London, UK

MRes, Economics (Distinction), 2022 to 2023

University of Oxford, UK

MPhil, Economics (Merit), 2019 to 2021

Nankai University, China

BSc, Economics (Distinction), 2015 to 2019

University of California, Berkeley, US

Exchange, Economics, 2018 to 2019

Fields

Labour Economics, Development Economics

Economics of Education

Applied Econometrics

References

Michela M. Tincani

Drayton House Room 308

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Áureo de Paula

Drayton House Room 228

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Orazio Attanasio

87 Trumbull Street, Room B321

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Fellowships & Awards

2025

RES Annual Conference: Scholars Fund

2019

Outstanding Graduates (5%), Nankai University

2017-2018

Tianjin Government Scholarship, Tianjin Municipal Government (8,000 RMB);

2017

Student Exchange Scholarship (30,000 RMB), Nankai University

Outstanding Student Leader (5%, 300 RMB), Nankai University

2016-2017

Woori Bank Scholarship (3,000 RMB), Nankai University

2015-2016

1st Class School Scholarship (5,000 RMB), Nankai University

Teaching

Statistical Methods in Economics(undergraduate), University College London, teaching fellow for Michela M. Tincani, 2023, 2024

Economics and Management UNIQ Summer School Programme, University of Oxford, teaching fellow for Janet Smart and Alex Teytelboym, 2021

Working Papers

Non-cognitive Development and Peer Effects: Experimental Evidence from Chinese Rural Boarding School Students (with Peiyi Jin)

Abstract: This paper evaluates the direct and spillover effects of a low-cost, scalable intervention—audio bedtime stories—on non-cognitive skill development among rural boarding school students in China. Using a randomized controlled trial (RCT), we analyze data from 63 schools, where boarding students were exposed to bedtime stories broadcast through dormitory speakers. This design isolates treated students from untreated day students in the same classroom, allowing for robust identification of peer effects in non-cognitive skill transmission. The results show significant positive effects on treated students, with larger gains for those with day-student friends and larger friendship networks. Spillover effects on untreated day students were primarily driven by those with boarding friends, highlighting the critical role of peer networks in the transmission of non-cognitive skills. We use the characteristics of peers' peers but not direct peers to instrument

peer resilience and self-esteem. Interacting with the treatment in the human capital production function, we will know how peers' outcomes affect one's own outcome and how the treatment changes the production function.

Unemployment and Higher Education: Evidence from Higher Education Expansion in China

Abstract: This paper exploits the 1999 nationwide higher education expansion in China to estimate the dynamics of the causal effect of the 1999 higher education, college degrees and years of schooling on labour market outcomes in China. Using the China Urban Household Survey and China Census data and a fuzzy regression discontinuity setting, this paper finds the expansion has worsened the economic outlook for college graduates in the short run but pays back in the long run in terms of unemployment propensity, getting a good job and wages.

Book Chapter

Peer Effects among Rural Adolescents (with Yaowu Wu), in Study on the Development of Rural Adolescent Non-Cognitive Skills, Social Sciences Academic Press (China), 2025, pp. 90–113.

Primary Data Collection

Study and Development of Junior High Students, China (2020)

Panel data on about 18,000 students in rural Sichuan and Hebei, with surveys covering students, teachers, and school principals. Responsible for leading survey collection, data cleaning (about 20,000 responses), and construction of non-cognitive skills measures.

Seminars & Conferences

2024 The Society of Labor Economists Annual Meeting; Annual Meeting of the European Association of Young Economists; The 16th China Economic Association (Europe) and 35th China Economic Association (UK) Annual Conference; UCL PhD Seminar; NUS Applied Economics Student Workshop; IFS-UCL-LSE/STICERD Development WiP Seminar

2025 Royal Economic Society Annual Conference; Stone Centre Conference on Education and Inequality; Janeway Institute Cambridge PhD workshop on economic networks; 2025 Young Economists Society (YES) Chengdu Forum

Academic Service

Organizer, University College London PhD Seminar, 2023–2024

Reviewer, Royal Economic Society PhD Conference 2024

Changemakers Project Partner, Faculty of Social & Historical Sciences, UCL, 2025

- Delivered a faculty-funded Changemakers project reviewing PGTA training and feedback.
- Conducted interviews with 30+ PGTAs and several academic directors, analysed NSS data, co-authored a policy report, and presented recommendations to the SHS Faculty Education Committee.

Volunteer Organizer, European Association of Young Economists Annual Meeting, 2025

Volunteer Contributor, Conference on Education and Inequality (Stone Center, 2025)

- authored social media threads and blog summaries of presented research

Languages

Mandarin (native); English (fluent); French (A2)

Software skills

Stata, Python, R, Matlab

Non-academic Service

Treasurer, University College London Tea Society, 2024

Student Representative, Department of Economics, Nankai University, 2017-2019

Training Director, the Youth Volunteer Association of the School of Economics, Nankai University, 2015-2017